

# An Epic DEVIATION

Gurcharan Das misreads the Mahabharata to understand a world without dharma

| By Bibek Debroy |



THE DIFFICULTY  
OF BEING GOOD:  
ON THE SUBTLE  
ART OF DHARMA

by GURCHARAN DAS

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Gurcharan Das has written plays and a novel. There was also a collection of essays titled *The Elephant Paradigm*. Notwithstanding these, he is remembered more for *India Unbound* and for his columns. By his own admission, that book was about *artha*. This is about dharma. There is therefore a 50 per cent probability that the next one might be about *kama*. There is a formidable array of advance praise marshalled in the book and a formidable amount of reading has gone into writing it. The volume is subtitled "On the Subtle Art of Dharma". Dharma is impossible to translate, as the author also acknowledges. Consequently, the title may appeal to Western-type audiences, but is singularly inappropriate. Dharma isn't about being good. That would be a narrow and misleading interpretation of dharma. Das has first delved into India Yesterday, namely, the Mahabharata. There is a Bhandarkar Critical Edition of the Sanskrit Text, which is the one the author uses. Part has been translated into English, courtesy the University of Chicago. This again is the version used and when Chicago isn't available, Clay Sanskrit Library has been used. Incidentally, in pre-Chicago and pre-Bhandarkar days, it is not true that the only "full-scale English translation" was by K.M. Ganguly. There was one by M.N. Dutt too.

There are layers within dharma. Das focuses on two—*svadharma* and *sadharana dharma*. By the former, he means *varnashrama dharma*, dharma appropriate for one's *varna* and one's *ashrama* (stage in life). By the latter, he means some universal notion of morality or "being good". However, the

subtle dharma of the Mahabharata has an individual dimension too, one that it isn't collective. To take but one example, both Bhishma and Arjuna were in a state of celibacy (Bhishma's permanent, Arjuna's temporary) when they were approached by women who desired them badly enough for dire consequences to result if they were repulsed. Bhishma took one decision, Arjuna another. The Mahabharata is littered with conflicts over dharma and Arjuna's confusion in Bhagavad Gita isn't the only instance. Faced with such conflicts, who knows what superior dharma is? Who knows what is right and what is wrong? Who knows what is good and what is bad? This is beyond the issue about dharma being context-specific. And if we bring in the free will versus determinism issue, we go off on another tangent. Consequently, the author has perhaps asked the wrong question. There is nothing like being good in an absolute sense.

Had Das restricted himself to India yesterday and discussed moral dilemmas in the Mahabharata alone, he would have produced another excellent volume like Chaturvedi Badrinath. However, his intention is to transcend this. He wants to link dilemmas of that era with India today and even the World today. But before that, one wishes for greater care with transcription of Sanskrit words. Why does *vanaprasthya* (sic) have a "y" and why does *sanyasa* (sic) have a single "n"? These aren't isolated examples, nor are these typos. There are several such. By the way, Nakula and Sahadeva are never referred to as Kounteya (p44). To link India yesterday with India today, Das fixes on certain dramatis personae—Duryodhana, Draupadi, Yudhishtira (in two separate chapters), Arjuna, Bhishma, Karna, Krishna

and Ashwatthama. And there are autobiographical elements too, with the author's father, mother and grandfather figuring. There can be no complaints about this choice of characters. People have written about the Mahabharata for ages, trying to understand why these dramatis personae behaved the way they did, and these are indeed (barring Ashwatthama) the most popular.

Barring the prelude and conclusion, nine out of 10 chapters are linked to traits these characters exhibit and

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